

NATION

'Nation' is essentially a European concept, and it is interesting to recall that during the Middle Ages groups of students from one country working in the European universities were called nations. The new word itself came into use in the second half of the nineteenth century. Some people used it in the sense of a group of people who have certain things in common: you are a nationality if you have national aspirations, if you are a group potentially but not actually a nation. Others made it a spiritual or abstract or subjective aspect of nationhood: you have nationality if you feel that you are one of a separate group.

The **first** and the most pre-eminent is the common group feeling which inspires the members of a nation. 'We all belong to one nation' expresses this sentiment. The **second**, flowing from the first, is the love for fellow nationals. This certainly does not mean that, say, every Pakistani loves or likes every other Pakistani; but it does mean that in a foreign country Pakistanis will tend to get together, or, on a personal level, in a quarrel with a Pakistani and a foreigner, other Pakistanis will normally side with their compatriot. The **third**, which is a consequence of the first two, is common hostility to other like groups. Before 1947 the Muslims of India, who considered themselves a nation, looked with hostility upon the Hindus and the Sikhs. This hostility is in proportion to the threat which one national group poses to the existence of the other. This feeling is inevitable in a country or geographical area occupied by more than one nation, particularly if one national group feels that its existence is denied or opposed or threatened or even criticized by the other, for example, in the pre-1947 Imperial India or in the pre-1919 Ottoman Empire.

The **fourth** is a common territory possessed or coveted by a nation. Once the emotion of nationalism has been aroused, territory is the first and an indispensable step towards the establishment of a State. In India the Muslims claimed the Muslim-majority provinces as their homeland. The Jews have similarly claimed and won Israel as their historical and national home. The **fifth** is the existence of a common sovereign government or the desire for it. This is the second step after a territory has been mentally demarcated and the claim to it staked. **Sovereignty, or politically speaking independence, is usually the final goal of all nationalist movements.** Freedom is evident and apparent objective which has been invoked by all colonial peoples struggling to be their own masters. The **sixth** is the existence of common moral, social or economic institutions or ideas. Medieval history provides some examples of nationalism (though this word was then not used to describe the movement) based on the Christian religion. In our age nationalism has had such formidable inspirations as Communism, National Socialism and Fascism.

The **seventh** is the possession of some common cultural characteristics, such as language, customs, manners, literature, art, music and folk-lore. If a person shares these with others and wants to go on sharing them he is a member of that nation. Culture, in its broader sense, is the most lasting foundation of nationalism. The **eighth** is common religion. In the secularism of the twentieth century religion has lost much of its force, yet it has produced the two most controversial nation-states of the post-war period Pakistan and Israel. The **ninth** is common history or common origin. Whether this history is real or invented is pointless so long as the members of a nation believe in it and look upon certain common historical figures as national heroes. Similarly, though modern science rejects both the theory and the

purity of races, the feeling of common racial origin may lead to solidarity of sorts, as the modern Arab movements illustrate.

The **tenth** is a common character shared by the national group. Geography, history, religion and culture combine to mould the contours of national character. The **eleventh** is a common pride in national achievements and a common sorrow in national tragedies. Traditionally this pride attached to feats of arms and this sorrow to military reverses. But in our technological age, scientific competition, economic rivalry and even educational jealousy are largely replacing the race for armaments. The **twelfth** is simple devotion to the nation. 'My country, right or wrong' is one expression, an extreme one perhaps, of this feeling. The last is the hope that the nation will one day be great, or, if it is already that, the greatest in the world. This aspiration may work in many directions, depending on the nation's mood and background: territorial expansion, military power, scientific advance or, in rare cases, academic glory.

The theory by Miroslav Hroch merits a special mention here. In his ***"From National Movement to the Fully-formed Nation: The Nation-building Process in Europe"***, he comes up with rather an interesting thesis. He classifies a nation as "a large social group integrated by a wide array of integrated factors, political, social, economic, geographical, cultural, and historical, and not just one factor. He lists three elements responsible for creating a nation:

1. a memory of a common past treated as a destiny of the group;
2. a density of linguistic or cultural ties facilitating a higher degree of communication within that group or beyond.
3. a belief in the equality of all of the members of the group regulated as a civil society.

FOUR STAGES OF NATIONALISM

The order in which these conditions have been given reflects the nature and composition of nationalism. Each of the four preceding paragraphs describes its evolution. The first enumerates the three feelings (oneness, love for fellow nationals, and hostility to other groups) which make up the emotional basis of nationalism. The second mentions the three factors (territory, sovereignty, and social ideas) which form its political and social apparatus. The third lists the four beliefs (culture, religion, history, and character) which constitute its spiritual equipment. The fourth portrays the sentiment of nationalism on three time-levels: pride in historical achievements relates to the past, devotion to the national cause concerns the present, the wish to achieve greatness is a hope of the future.